

What is a computer program?

A computer program is a set of instructions that a computer follows to complete a task. “Coding”, or “programming”, means writing the step-by-step instructions that tell the computer what to do.

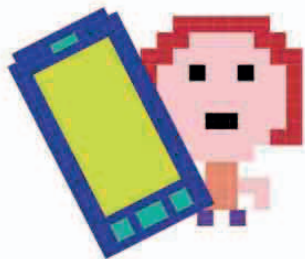
Computer programs are everywhere

We are surrounded by computer programs. Many of the devices and gadgets we use every day are controlled by them. These machines all follow step-by-step instructions written by a computer programmer.

SEE ALSO

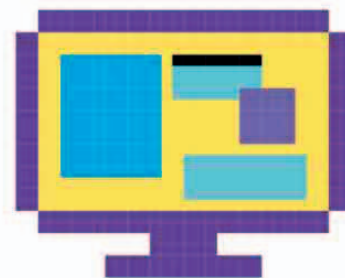
Thinking like **16–17** >
a computer

Becoming **18–19** >
a coder



◁ Mobile phones

Programs allow you to make a phone call or send text messages. When you search for a contact, a program finds the correct phone number.



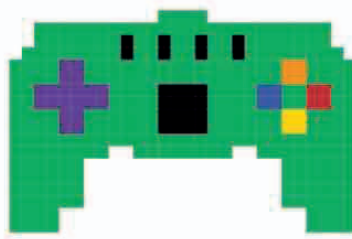
△ Computer software

Everything a computer does, from browsing the Internet to writing documents or playing music, works because of code written by a computer programmer.



△ Washing machines

Washing machines are programmed to follow different cycles. Computer code controls how hot the water is and how long the wash takes.



◁ Games

Consoles are just another type of computer, and all the games that run on them are programs. All the graphics, sounds, and controls are written in computer code.

▷ Cars

In some cars, computer programs monitor the speed, temperature, and amount of fuel in the tank. Computer programs can even help control the brakes to keep people safe.

